Patching Knees

Two friendly ways to fix a worn or torn knee: an iron-on patch (fast) or sew-on fabric (durable). Both are beginner-safe.

What you need:

- An iron-on patch, or a piece of fabric shaped slightly larger than the hole
- An iron (for iron-on) or needle, thread, and scissors (for sew-on)
- Pins or a few binder clips to hold fabric in place

Method 1: Iron-on patch (about 10 minutes)

1. Turn the pants inside out and trim any dangling threads around the hole. Don't cut away the hole itself; the patch will cover it.
2. Turn them right side out and lay them flat on the ironing board with the knee area smooth.
3. Peel the paper backing off the patch and press it over the hole, sticky side down.
4. Set the iron to the setting your pants label allows, turn off the steam, and press firmly for 20–30 seconds. Hold still — pressing works better than sliding.
5. Flip the pants inside out and press again from the inside for another 15 seconds.
6. Optional but even better: whipstitch around the patch edge (see below) so it survives the wash and the playground.

Method 2: Sew-on fabric patch (about 30 minutes)

1. Cut a fabric patch an inch bigger than the hole all the way around. Snip the corners rounded so they don't peel up later.
2. Turn the pants inside out and place the patch over the hole, then pin it in place.
3. Stitch around the edge with a simple whipstitch: poke the needle through both layers near the edge, pull the thread snug, then move a quarter inch along and repeat.
4. Knot off the thread on the inside and trim. On the outside, the mend blends in because you did all the sewing from behind.

Kind tips: A patch the shape of a star, heart, or lightning bolt turns a repair into a feature. Wash your mended pants inside out to keep the patch crisp.